READING 2.3 · SHIP AND OCEAN SYSTEMS DESIGN

The Admiralty Law

Power, speed and displacement for one hull form: the physics, the deduction, its limits, parent ships and a worked example

Papanikolaou (2026) §1.3, §2.3, §2.14 · Session W2.3 · extended reading after Lecture 2.3a, not for evaluation

Tiago Santos, Luís Batista

Instituto Superior Técnico / University of Lisbon

tiago.santos@centec.tecnico.ulisboa.pt

luis@veranavis.com

calendly.com/vnsd-luisbatista/meetme

Where the Admiralty Law Comes From

1

$$R_T = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\rho\, S\, V^2\, C_T$$

Resistance: dynamic pressure × wetted surface × a coefficient

2

$$P_E = R_T\, V, \qquad P_B = \frac{P_E}{\eta_D\, \eta_S}$$

Power: effective, then brake through the propulsive and shaft efficiencies

3

$$S = k_S\, \nabla^{2/3}, \qquad \Delta = \rho\, \nabla$$

Same hull shape: S ∝ L² and ∇ ∝ L³, so S grows with ∇ to the 2/3 (Taylor, Eq. 2.8)

4

$$P_B = \frac{\rho^{1/3}\, k_S\, C_T}{2\, \eta_D\, \eta_S}\, \Delta^{2/3}\, V^3 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad C = \frac{\Delta^{2/3}\, V^3}{P}$$

Hold CT, ηD, ηS and kS: what is left is the Admiralty constant (2.104)

Symbols

RT total resistance [kN]

ρ sea water, 1.025 t/m³

S wetted surface [m²]

V speed [m/s]; [kn] in C

CT resistance coefficient

PE, PB effective, brake power [kW]

ηD, ηS propulsive, shaft efficiency

∇ displaced volume [m³]

Δ displacement [t]

kS shape constant of the hull

C Admiralty constant

C ∝ ηD / (kS·CT): constant only while the hull form, Fn and Rn stay the same. In 2.104: Δ [t], V [kn], P [kW]; typical C 400–600, higher for efficient designs.

Power, Speed and Displacement: Three Relations

Power for a new speed or displacement

$$\frac{P_2}{P_1} = \left(\frac{\Delta_2}{\Delta_1}\right)^{2/3} \left(\frac{V_2}{V_1}\right)^{3}$$

Speed for a new power or displacement

$$\frac{V_2}{V_1} = \left(\frac{P_2}{P_1}\right)^{1/3} \left(\frac{\Delta_1}{\Delta_2}\right)^{2/9}$$

Displacement for a new power or speed

$$\frac{\Delta_2}{\Delta_1} = \left(\frac{P_2}{P_1}\right)^{3/2} \left(\frac{V_1}{V_2}\right)^{9/2}$$

Same ship, same C: write 2.104 for state 1 and state 2, and divide.

Change one by +10 %, hold another: the third follows

Hold	Change	Result
Δ	V +10 %	P +33.1 %
V	Δ +10 %	P +6.6 %
P	Δ +10 %	V −2.1 %
Δ	P +10 %	V +3.2 %
P	V +10 %	Δ −34.9 %

Speed is expensive, displacement is cheap: power goes with V³ but only with Δ to the 2/3.

The book’s use (§1.3): C measured on sea trials at a reduced draught gives the speed at the design displacement with the installed power.

Order of Resistance, Order of Power, and the Humps

$$R \propto V^{\,n} \;\Rightarrow\; P \propto V^{\,m}, \quad m = n + 1, \qquad C \propto V^{\,3-m}$$

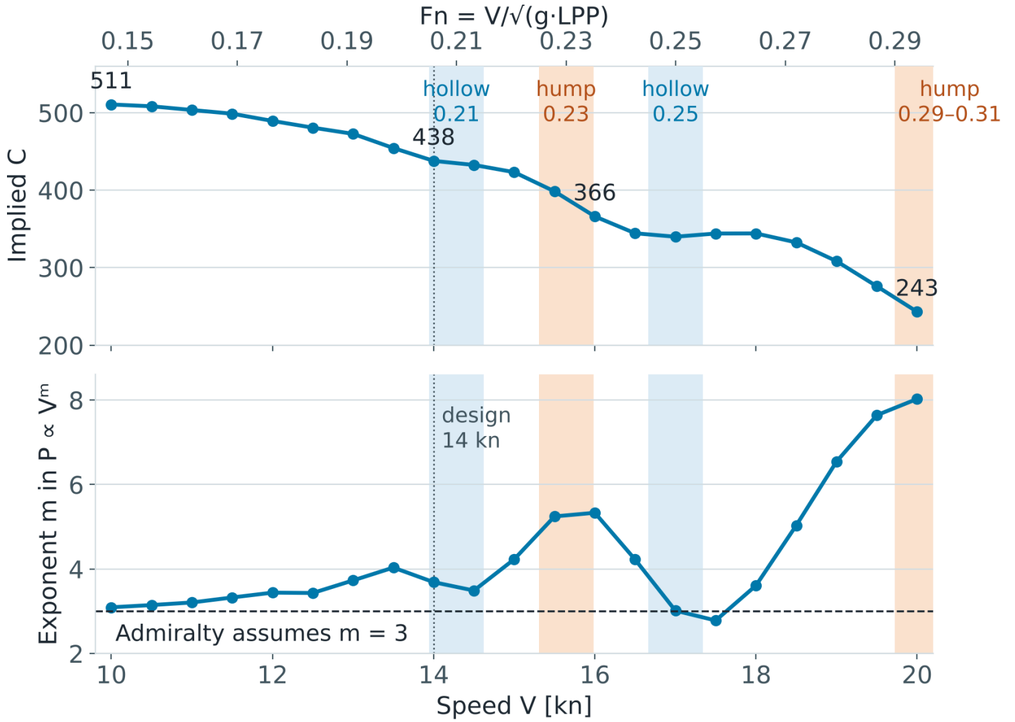
The Admiralty law is the case n = 2 (CT constant), so m = 3.

$$C_F = \frac{0.072}{R_n^{0.2}} \;\Rightarrow\; R_F \propto V^{1.8}, \quad P_F \propto V^{2.8}$$

Friction alone (Prandtl, Eq. 2.9): m just below 3.

Waves: CW swings with Fn (Fig. 2.14). Towards a hump m rises above 3 and C falls; in a hollow m drops back to about 3.

Reference ship: m 3.1 at 10 kn; above 5 at 15.5–16 kn, on the 0.23 hump; 2.8 at 17.5 kn, in the 0.25 hollow. C falls from 511 to 243.



Use C only for the same hull form at similar L and V (Rn, Fn), with one power definition, for small changes, and never across a hump.

Getting C from Parent Ships

1. Collect parents in D2: same type, similar L, Fn and CB.
2. One power definition for all: MCR, SMCR, service PB or trial PD.
3. C for each; use the closest parent, not the 400–600 range.
4. The spread of C is your uncertainty: carry it into the power and the machinery weight.

Source	Δ [t]	V [kn]	P [kW]	Basis	C
Lecture 1.5, assumed	13,200.7	14	3,832	installed	400
Holtrop–Mennen	13,200.7	12	1,972	SMCR	489
Holtrop–Mennen	13,200.7	14	3,500	SMCR	438
Holtrop–Mennen	13,200.7	16	6,248	SMCR	366
Parent 1 · your D2	…	…	…	…	…
Parent 2 · your D2	…	…	…	…	…

The reference ship rows: Lecture 1.5 and Tool 2.4. One hull already spans C 366–489 between 12 and 16 kn.

Units: P in metric hp gives C(kW)/1.36; V in m/s gives another constant.

Basis: SMCR = 1.28·PB (15 % margin, 90 % MCR), so C on PB is 1.28 × C on SMCR.

Variants: Völker (2.105) uses V^3.6; Heickel (2.106) a similar coefficient.

One Constant, a Domain of Ships

$$C = \frac{\Delta_0^{2/3}\, V_0^3}{P_0} = \frac{13\,200.7^{2/3} \cdot 14^3}{3\,500} = 438$$

Parent: the reference ship at 14 kn, SMCR by Holtrop–Mennen. Δ changed through the draught, L and B fixed. Each cell: Admiralty / Holtrop–Mennen.

SMCR [kW] for Δ and V

Δ / Δ0	13 kn	14 kn	15 kn
0.90	2,612 / 2,433	3,263 / 3,272	4,013 / 4,152
1.00	2,803 / 2,596	3,500 / 3,500	4,305 / 4,454
1.10	2,986 / 2,753	3,730 / 3,723	4,588 / 4,750

Speed [kn] on the same 3,500 kW

Δ / Δ0	Admiralty / H–M
0.80	14.71 / 14.62
0.90	14.33 / 14.28
1.00	14.00 / 14.00
1.05	13.85 / 13.88
1.10	13.71 / 13.78

Δ scales well: within 1 % at 14 kn, ±10 % of Δ.

V scales only near the parent: +8 % at 13 kn, −3 % at 15 kn, because m ≠ 3.

Design loop: 5 % more Δ costs 3.3 % power at 14 kn, or 0.15 kn on the same engine.